



Upgrading my Ubuntu installation took two days on my connection—I would classify anything above 20 MB as a heavy download”

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But Why?

That's the question a colleague asked me recently as I was narrating tales of my days of uploading joy. To be honest, I still don't know... perhaps it is this unsaid character that's woven into our subconscious from Day 1: "Never let an opportunity by," "Waste not, want not," and various other little pearls of wisdom we're subjected to as kids. All I know is that, at the time, having the capability to upload at 400 Kbps and *not* uploading anything seemed a *crime*!

Today, so many of us have unlimited, always-on connections with speeds between 64 and 256 Kbps that the phenomenon described above is more commonplace. I asked around and found I'm not special (as in "He needs *special* schooling!"), and hordes of people are doing exactly the same thing with their connections.

Warez

We all know that many of us are downloading illegally using P2P clients. Of course, most of it really isn't a waste of time and bandwidth, but very often, especially for people with 256 Kbps unlimited connections and above, you soon run out of things to download—you already have all the latest movies, you have all the music you like, now what? Some of the people I spoke to claimed to just start downloading whatever everyone else was downloading—especially the torrent users. "The advantage with torrent sites is that they list the latest uploads as

well as the most popular ones, so all I do is choose a nice big file that interests me and set it to download," said a college student from Mumbai on condition of anonymity.

"What if you already have those files?" I asked. "Then there's always enough porn to download," he replied.

Pornography

It didn't surprise me when most of the people I spoke to said they downloaded porn when not downloading anything else. Then there was a student from a well-known college in Bandra, Mumbai, who said, "Well, actually, my bandwidth is used mostly to download porn, but when I'm not doing that, I surf casually looking for interesting software or a good print of a movie."

Pornography was such a popular choice, I almost didn't feel like adding it to this list of *Timepass Tips*—it seems more of a primary use for broadband! Anyway, one thing is clear, a lot of people (almost all male) spend a lot of time using their bandwidth to enhance their knowledge of the private lives of the birds and the bees.

Open Source Psychopaths

It's really no secret that there are thousands of open source supporters who feel compelled to have Anti-Microsoft feelings. If not Microsoft, these people generally dislike all the big corporate software companies—Symantec, Adobe and the like. So

it should come as no surprise that some of them spend all their free time plotting to take over the world from those they think have taken over the world!

One such friend of mine uses FreeBSD as his OS. He's in the US, but I have an account on his box. Imagine my surprise when I saw that he had queued up almost every trial version Microsoft has on offer for download at Microsoft.com. "Converting to Windows?" I asked. I should have known better: "Nah, just putting my 3 Mbps connection to some good use and doing my bit towards wasting some of Microsoft's bandwidth." Turns out there are a group of 30 or so of them, all of whom use open source operating systems, and all of whom set up scripts to download anything available at Microsoft.com when they're not doing anything—and oh, they all have 3 Mbps connections or faster! So if you're trying to download something from Microsoft and aren't exactly getting blazing speeds, you have my friends to thank for that!

Online Gaming

Gaming is turning out to be a very popular use for broadband. Though most of us are more likely to go to places like Yahoo! games, an increasing number of Indians are getting addicted to online MMORPGs (Massively Multiplayer Online Role Playing Games). If not that, then it's multiplayer First Person Shooter (FPS) games—*Counter Strike* is the clear winner here for India. Most of the people I spoke to were obsessed with *Counter Strike*, and wanted even more servers to play on. Broadband connections bring with them a wonderful "value-added service": the local LAN setup you get within your neighbourhood! With a population density ants would be proud of, Indian metros are generally divided into areas of dominance by ISPs. So chances are that the ISP you have a broadband connection from is also supplying everyone in your local area, which translates to a nice LAN setup for gaming—with blazingly fast ping times and the opportunity to be famous amongst peers you actually meet!

Multimedia

With broadband, no longer do we need to avoid pages that con-

Hilarious!

Here are some of the wackiest quotes I got when asking how people trash their time and grab their bandwidth:

"For about a month, it had to be visiting the Digit Forum after its shift to vBulletin, when you guys didn't enable gzip compression! 300 KB a page was a real waste of bandwidth!"

All readers should know that this has since been fixed, and it was only for 12 days that we had this problem!

"I download homosexual porn, zip it, and rename it to one of the latest software releases. I then share it on P2P networks—just doing my bit for the fight against piracy."

"All I seem to do online is browse through Amazon.com, looking for good books. When I find one, I head over to my favourite torrent sites or an IRC network and get the e-book!"

"I use P2P 24x7, and download everything I can. But it's not what you think... I'm actually looking to build a huge repository of viruses, and I get a new one almost every day via P2P, which one day I shall unleash on my college computers. Why? Because they overcharge students, reserve half the seats, and I know more than my computer professor does about computers!"

"When I'm really bored, I open up wikimapia.com and add some bogus and funny places in India. The most recent one I added was a friend's house—only I added it in on top of a sewage pipeline!"